

THE BRIEF

AUDIENCE

NCAD member institutions, Reach leadership & prospective funders

FRAMING

Operating proposal — charter a shared lab

THE REFRAME

The people who understand the problem can finally build the thing

THE ASK

Charter & fund the lab — grant-funded, shared-good output

KEY SIGNALS

2024

NCAD launched by Reach University

2025

"Vibe coding" named

2026

Tools mature for non-engineers

~144h

Related instruction / yr (accreditation)

THREADS

Vibe Coding

Domain Experts

Work ↔ Credit

Voice-First

Shared Infra

Member Network

Fast-moving facts (tool names, the vibe-coding timeline, accreditation hours, member count) are flagged for verification before presenting.

OPERATING PROPOSAL · SHARED LAB

Prototype with experts; harden with engineers.

The Apprenticeship Degree runs on a different technology stack — one that integrates work and learning, gives employers visibility, and delivers chunked, assessable learning to busy adults while meeting accreditation. Historically only expensive engineering teams could build it. As of 2026, agentic "vibe coding" lets the domain experts closest to the problem prototype it themselves. This is the proposal to stand that capability up as a shared lab at NCAD.

- ▶ **A different stack — and nobody built it.** Legacy LMSS, university SISS, and online-program platforms each solve a slice; none solve the whole.
- ▶ **Who builds has changed.** Vibe coding moved prototyping from the engineering team to the domain expert; engineers still own hardening, scale, and security.
- ▶ **One network, one lab.** NCAD's member network pools prototypes so no member rebuilds what another already proved.

01 A DIFFERENT STACK

The Apprenticeship Degree must **integrate work and learning** (the job is the curriculum), give employers **visibility and a way to encourage** apprentices, and deliver **chunked learning + assessment** to busy adults — all while satisfying credit-bearing accreditation. Incumbents built parts; the whole is unbuilt.

02 WHO BUILDS HAS CHANGED

"Vibe coding" — building software by describing intent to an AI — matured by 2026 into something a **non-engineer can ship real prototypes with** (Cursor, v0, Lovable, Bolt, Replit Agent, Claude Code). Engineers are no longer the gate on prototyping; the domain experts who know the problem now build it.

03 HOW THE LAB WORKS

- **Domain experts prototype** — working software in hours/days.
- **Test** with real cohorts/employers inside member programs.
- **Circulate** across members through NCAD.
- **Engineers harden** what proves out.

04 CANDIDATE FIRST BUILDS

- Work ↔ credit mapping (accreditation-legible).
- Employer visibility & encouragement dashboard.
- Chunked delivery + stackable assessment.
- **Voice-first evidence capture** — capture in the moment; the commute becomes learning time.

CHARTER THE LAB

Fund a small standing capability — domain-expert builders + part-time engineering + tool budget — hosted at NCAD, governed by and serving the member network. **Grant-funded, shared-good output:** shared infrastructure for the field, not a commercial bet. **So no member rebuilds what another already proved.**

Sources: NCAD — National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree • NCAD Executive Overview (OADN, 2024) • JFF Work-Based Learning Glossary (~144 hrs related instruction) • Ithaka S+R, "Understanding Work-Based Learning" • "The Vibe Coding Bakeoff" (Bolt/Lovable/Replit/v0) • "Best Vibe Coding Tools 2026" • "Low-Code, High Impact: Why 2026 Belongs to Citizen Developers" — draft narrative; fast-moving facts pending verification.